



MARRAKECH MOROCCO

Spicy Tagine in the City of Souks

The sunset tinges the distant Atlas Mountains a deep rose-red, and the call to prayer echoes from the turret of the Koutoubia Mosque. This is the time for the snake-charmers and henna artists of Jemaa el-Fna square to make way for the food-laden stands of Marrakech's night food market. Take a stroll around the spectacle before tucking into a traditional Moroccan tagine.



An oasis in every sense of the word, Marrakech was once a beacon for trading caravans that had traveled north through the desert and navigated over the often snow-capped Atlas Mountains. The

fabulous palaces and lush palms of the city have always been where sub-Saharan Africa meets Arab North Africa, and even today this market town on the edge of nowhere remains a compellingly exotic port of call.

Life in the medina – the old walled city – revolves around the towering medieval minaret of the Koutoubia Mosque. For many visitors, though, this is eclipsed by the atmospheric Jemaa el-Fna, the nerve center of Marrakech, with its weird and wonderful cast of artists and performers – from water-sellers to fortune-tellers – and spectacular, frenetic food market.

Next head for the ancient souk – a vast area of higgledy-piggledy, cupboard-sized shops and stands filling dozens of narrow alleyways. Delicious smells draw you farther into the endless maze of lanes, where stands are laden with bundles of fresh mint, jars of plump olives infused with lemon and garlic, and bright pyramids of spice. Intricately made leather goods, metalwork, inlaid boxes, brass lanterns, carpets, and

jewelry overflow the tables and floor. Slightly less overwhelming are the food and spice markets of the Mellah, the old Jewish quarter; the Place des Ferblantiers, where tinsmiths make and sell their wares, is a relative haven from the hustle and bustle. Find a rooftop café terrace for a refreshing mint tea – and look for white storks, soaring to their nests on top of the old royal tombs and palaces.

After a day's sightseeing, shopping, or wandering the souk, there is nothing better than sitting down to enjoy a rich, fragrant tagine – the signature dish of Morocco. This aromatic dish combines meat – usually lamb, sometimes chicken – with fruit (often dried), vegetables, and a heady mix of herbs and spices, including saffron, cumin, coriander, and nutmeg.

The concoction is then braised slowly over a bed of charcoal in its distinctive and eponymous clay pot. The traditional conical-lidded dish synonymous with tagine – effectively a robust, portable cooking pot and serving dish all in one – originated with the Berber and Tuareg tribes of the Sahara. The use of dried fruits and the emphasis on aromatic spices also stem from this nomadic culture. Marrakech may have smartened itself up a little in recent years for the tourist trade, but its ancient desert heart still beats strong.

A Day in Marrakech

The rich history of Marrakech is reflected in its various quarters. The medina corresponds to the old town, with Jemaa el-Fna, the hub of all activity, at its heart. Within the ramparts are the souks, the kasbah, and the Mellah.

MORNING Start at **Jemaa el-Fna**, the vast square at the heart of the medina, which is as old as Marrakech itself. Just off the square, and dominating Marrakech's skyline, is the tower of the **Koutoubia Mosque**. Like most mosques in Morocco, it is closed to non-Muslims, but is an impressive sight nonetheless.

AFTERNOON Laid out in the narrow streets north of Jemaa el-Fna are a spectacular array of **souks**, or bazaars, selling everything from carpets and slippers to magic spells, in which you can while away whole mornings or afternoons. Continue to the **city walls** that enclose the medina, studded with 20 ornamental gates.

EVENING Return to **Jemaa el-Fna**, which transforms itself at night into a circus, theater, and restaurant, with itinerant musicians and entertainers drawing crowds.

Essentials

GETTING THERE

Menara International Airport is 2 miles (4 km) from the downtown. **Taxis** are readily available.

WHERE TO STAY

Hôtel Sherazade (inexpensive) has simple rooms within a *riad* (traditional Moorish town house). www.hotelsherazade.com

Tchaikana (moderate) is a beautiful *riad* within the medina. www.tchaikana.com

La Maison Arabe (expensive) was the first boutique hotel in Marrakech, and offers luxury and comfort. www.lamaisonarabe.com

TOURIST INFORMATION

Place Abdelmoumen Ben Ali (Av Mohammed V).

